

Empowering finance

Atom automates payment collection

Sahayata, an Udaipur-based micro-finance institution (MFI), was using the very basic level of transaction entry/recording system for collections/disbursements. As it grew in operations, it needed a technology that could work on the field (villages) and provide real-time recording of the transactions.

Sahayata used to follow a structure where a field officer (FO) was assigned a specific territory for collection/disbursements. These FOs were always on the move within a territory and there was a lack of transaction recording on Sahayata's backend.

Atom's mobile-based m-Collections solution can be connected to the Sahayata backend via GPRS to enable real-time data recording. Also, it is very cost-effective, as there is no requirement for additional hardware, other than the Java MIDP 2.0 enabled handsets for the FOs. The only additional requirement is the GPRS

connectivity. The application supports both GSM and CDMA technologies, which provides better reach to any of the geographical locations having mobile connectivity.

Atom's mobile-based m-Collections solution assists Sahayata in automating the loan disbursement and payment collections process. It interfaces with their system for enabling transactions to flow through. The solution is based on JEE and J2ME technologies.

The solution brings to Sahayata four benefits:

1. Affordability (the model doesn't require any major hardware deployment)
2. Scalability (the model suffices the future needs)
3. Simple to use (the model works on normal mobile phones, providing convenience to FOs)
4. Compatibility with the current system (the model integrates with the current backend system)

Making communication easier

Huawei solutions for affordable voice and data services

Wireless networking is the most economical way to quickly deploy communication services in rural areas. Huawei's rural communication solutions have been helping many operators in the emerging market to capture the market potential by offering affordable voice and data services for a relatively low investment.

The interesting features of its solutions are:

1. Fewer BTS but wider coverage. BTS adopt power boost technology, transmission/receiver diversity and multiple carriers. These greatly improve transmission power and receiver sensitivity, thus achieving wider coverage with fewer BTS.
2. Construction and auxiliary cost reductions. The all-in-one compact BTS have transmission devices and batteries built into them. Their capacity is bigger and they are easy to expand, so these can be deployed in small town and village centres. On the other hand, the distributed BTS are small and easy to deploy. These can be deployed in hot spots, such as small villages and scenic areas. The compact BTS can serve as the transmission hub for the distributed BTS. The expenditure on power supply, transmission, air-conditioning, site rental and maintenance can be greatly saved with these two types of BTS.
3. Transmission savings. Not only do they provide a range of solutions including all-IP BSS and core to save the transmission construction cost but also innovations such as MGW-BSC co-cabinet, HUB-BTS, Abis transmission optimisation and IP over E1/T1 to save long-distance transmission rental.
3. Scalable network. Huawei's core and IP bearer networks and service platform support coexistence of 2G and 3G networks. This expedites the dynamic adjustment of 2G/3G network resources according to subscriber requirements, while realising smooth service evolution.

BT's phone-based help service for farmers

India's rural farmers work in a very difficult environment and are faced with daily challenges. Crop failure or animal illness can be catastrophic for them and help is not always readily available, mainly due to the very limited communications facilities in rural areas. The answers to many of the problems may well be available on the Internet, but this is way beyond the reach of the vast majority.

BT approached OneWorld—a charitable organisation working to promote human rights and sustainable development across the globe—to explore ideas for a telephone-based information service to enable farmers to record a question and, soon after, retrieve a recorded reply. BT engaged with Cisco to co-sponsor the initiative.

LifeLines India was launched in November 2006. The solution comprises a Cisco unified messaging platform incorporating interactive voice response functionality, integrated with a customer relationship management application and information database provided by BT. Cisco and BT also jointly sponsor OneWorld, which manages and operates the service.

Coverage currently extends to 591 villages and more than 200 calls to the service are being received each day. A database of over 30,000 'frequently asked questions' has been created. Not only is this vital to help deliver a prompt service to farmers, it is key to enabling service scalability and sustainability. Crop quality and efficiency have already improved and some farmers have seen profits increase by 25 to 150 per cent.